A-A-53603
28 July 1988

COMMERCIAL ITEM DESCRIPTION

RETRACTOR, ABDOMINAL (Balfour, Self-Retaining)

The General Services Administration has authorized the use of this commercial item description as a replacement for Military Specifications MIL-R-0036982A(DM), which is cancelled.

This commercial item description covers a self-retaining, Balfour, abdominal retractor suitable for use in retaining around the incision in lower abdominal surgery.

Salient characteristics:

General. The self-retaining abdominal retractor of the Balfour design covered by this specification shall be of the following sizes as specified:

SIZE 1 6-1/2 inch opening

SIZE 2 10-1/2 inch opening

Material. The material of the retractor shall be Class 4 martensitic corrosion-resistant steel in accordance with American Society for Testing and Materials (ASTM) Designation F899.

Style, design and dimension. Size 1 retractors shall be supplied with one pair of small lateral blades, one pair of large lateral blades, and one small and one large supra-pubic blades. The retractor and blades shall be in accordance with DPSC Drawing No. 20568 for the National Stock Number (NSN) specified. As an alternate, size 1 retractors may be in accordance with DPSC Drawing No. 1286.

Size 2 retractors shall be supplied with one pair of small lateral blades, one pair of large lateral blades, and one small supra-pubic blade. The retractor and blades shall be in accordance with DPSC Drawing No. 20568 for the NSN specified.

AMSC N/A FSC 6515

DISTRIBUTION STATEMENT A. Approved for public release; distribution is unlimited.

Source: https://assist.dla.mil -- Downloaded: 2026-10-26T09:22Z
Check the source to verify that this is the current version before use.

Hardness. The retractor shall have a Rockwell Hardness C scale (HRC) of 40 to 46 when tested in accordance with ASTM Designations E18 or E92 whichever is applicable. Conversion of hardness values shall be in accordance with ASTM Designation E140.

Finish. The retractor shall be mirror, satin or matte finish. The matte finish shall exhibit a uniform nondirectional surface texture equivalent to that produced by lightly blasting the prepared surface with fine abrasives under pressure.

Passivation. The retractor shall be properly passivated.

Corrosion resistance. The retractor shall show no evidence of corrosion or plating of copper when tested in accordance with ASTM Designation F1089.

Identification markings. The retractor shall be marked in accordance with ASTM Designation F1026. In addition, the word "stainless" shall be inscribed into the instrument.

Workmanship. The retractor shall be free from defects which detract from its appearance or impair its serviceability.

Product Quality Level.

Visual and dimensional examination. Shall be examined to verify that design, construction and workmanship are in accordance with applicable requirements.

Materials. The supplier shall be responsible for performing tests to assure that materials are in accordance with requirements specified.

Unit. Each (EA). One retractor, as specified, constitutes one unit.

Source: https://assist.dla.mil -- Downloaded: 202640-26T09:22Z
Check the source to verify that this is the currentversion before use.

Quality Assurance Provisions.

Responsibility for inspection. Unless otherwise specified in the contract or purchase order, the contractor is responsible for the performance of all inspection requirements as specified herein. Except as otherwise specified in the contract or purchase order, the contractor may use his own or any facilities suitable for the performance of the inspection requirements specified herein, unless disapproved by the Government. The Government reserves the right to perform any of the inspections set forth in the specification where such inspections are deemed necessary to assure supplies and services conform to prescribed requirements.

Records. Records of examinations and tests performed by or for the contractor shall be maintained by the contractor and made available to the Government upon the Government's request, at any time, or from time to time, during the performance of the contract and for a period of three years after delivery of the supplies to which such records relate.

Inspection. Inspection, as used herein, is defined as both examination (such as visual or auditory investigation without the use of special laboratory appliances or procedures) and testing (determination by technical means of physical and chemical properties) of the item.

Sampling for examination. Sampling for examination shall be conducted in accordance with MIL-STD-105 and as specified herein. Unit of product for examination purposes shall be one retractor. Sampling shall be level II and and AQL of 1.0.

Examination. Examination shall be conducted to determine compliance with specification requirements.

Sampling for tests. Sampling for tests shall be in accordance with MIL-STD-105 and as specified herein. Unit of product for test purposes shall be one retractor. Sampling shall be level S-2 and an AQL of 1.0.

Tests. Tests shall be conducted to determine compliance with specification requirements. Where feasible, the same sample shall be used for the determination of two or more test characteristics.

Source: https://assist.dla.mil -- Downloaded: 2026-10-26T09:22Z
Check the source to verify that this is the current version before use.

Contractor certification. The contractor shall certify that the product offered meets the salient characteristics of this description and conforms to the producers' own drawings, specifications, standards, and quality assurance practices. The Government reserves the right to require proof of such conformance prior to first delivery and thereafter as may be otherwise provided for under the provisions of the contract.

Metric products. Products manufactured to metric dimensions will be considered on an equal basis with those manufactured using inch-pound units, providing they fall within the tolerances specified using conversion tables contained in the latest revision of Federal Standard No. 376, and all other requirements of this document are met.

If a product is manufactured to metric dimensions and those dimensions exceed the tolerances specified in the inch/pound units, a request should be made to the contracting officer to determine if the product is acceptable.

The contracting officer has the option of accepting or rejecting the product.

Regulatory requirements.

Federal Food, Drug and Cosmetic Act. If the product covered by this document has been determined by the U.S. Food and Drug Administration to be under its jurisdiction, the offeror/contractor shall comply, and be responsible for compliance by its subcontractors/suppliers, with the requirements of the Federal Food, Drug and Cosmetic Act, as amended, and regulations promulgated thereunder. In addition, the offeror/contractor shall comply, and be responsible for compliance by its subcontractors/suppliers, with the requirements of all other applicable Federal, State, and local statutes, ordinances, and regulations.

Recovered materials. The offeror contractor is encouraged to use recovered materials in accordance with Public Law 94-580 to the maximum extent practical.

Source: https://assist.dla.mil -- Downloaded: 202610-26T09:22Z
Check the source to verify that this is the current version before use.

Preservation, packaging, packing, labeling, and marking. Unless otherwise specified, preservation, packaging, and packing shall be to a degree of protection to preclude damage to containers and or contents thereof under normal shipping conditions, handling, etc., involving shipment from the supply source to the receiving activity, plus reshipment from receiving activity, and shall conform to applicable carrier's rules and regulations. Intermediate and exterior package quantities and labeling and marking shall be as specified in the contract and/or order.

NOTE: The following National Stock Numbers are covered by this document:

NSN	ITEM IDENTIFICATION
6515-00-360-4910	RETRACTOR, ABDOMINAL, Balfour, Self-Retaining 6-1/2 Inch Opening
6515-01-139-8969	RETRACTOR, ABDOMINAL, Balfour, Self-Retaining 10-1/2 Inch Opening

Ordering data (Intermediate/exterior package quantities and labeling and marking must be specified in the contract and/or order).

MILITARY INTERESTS:

Custodians:

Army - MD
Navy - MS
Air Force - 03

Preparing Activity:

DoD-MB

Agent:

DLA-DM

CIVIL AGENCY COORDINATING ACTIVITIES:

VA-OSS
PHS
FDA-MPQAS

Project No. 6515-4309

Source: https://assist.dla.mil -- Downloaded: 2026-10-26T09:22Z
Check the source to verify that this is the current version before use.

STANDARDIZATION DOCUMENT IMPROVEMENT PROPOSAL

(See Instructions – Reverse Side)

1 DOCUMENT NUMBER	2 DOCUMENT TITLE
A-A-53603	RETRACTOR, ABDOMINAL (Balfour, Self-Retaining)

3a NAME OF SUBMITTING ORGANIZATION	4 TYPE OF ORGANIZATION *(Mark one)*
	☐ VENDOR
	☐ USER
b ADDRESS *(Street City State ZIP Code)*	☐ MANUFACTURER
	☐ OTHER *(Specify)* _____

5 PROBLEM AREAS

a Paragraph Number and Wording

b Recommended Wording

c Reason/Rationale for Recommendation

6 REMARKS

7a NAME OF SUBMITTER *(Last First MI – Optional*	b WORK TELEPHONE NUMBER *(Include Area Code) – Optional*
c MAILING ADDRESS *(Street City State ZIP Code) – Optional*	8 DATE OF SUBMISSION *(YYMMDD)*

DD FORM 82 MAR 1426

PREVIOUS EDITION IS OBSOLETE

Source: https://assist.dla.mil -- Downloaded: 2026-10-26T09:22Z
Check the source to verify that this is the current version before use.

INSTRUCTIONS In a continuing effort to make our standardization documents better, the DoD provides this form for use in submitting comments and suggestions for improvements. All users of military standardization documents are invited to provide suggestions. This form may be detached, folded along the lines indicated, taped along the loose edge *(DO NOT STAPLE)*, and mailed. In block 5, be as specific as possible about particular problem areas such as wording which required interpretation, was too rigid, restrictive, loose, ambiguous, or was incompatible, and give proposed wording changes which would alleviate the problems. Enter in block 6 any remarks not related to a specific paragraph of the document. If block 7 is filled out, an acknowledgement will be mailed to you within 30 days to let you know that your comments were received and are being considered.

NOTE This form may not be used to request copies of documents, nor to request waivers, deviations or clarification of specification requirements on current contracts. Comments submitted on this form do not constitute or imply authorization to waive any portion of the referenced document(s) or to amend contractual requirements.

(Fold along this line)

(Fold along this line)

DEFENSE LOGISTICS AGENCY

NO POSTAGE NECESSARY IF MAILED IN THE UNITED STATES

OFFICIAL BUSINESS
PENALTY FOR PRIVATE USE $300

BUSINESS REPLY MAIL
FIRST CLASS PERMIT NO. 4966 WASHINGTON D.C.

POSTAGE WILL BE PAID BY THE DEFENSE LOGISTICS AGENCY

Commander
Defense Personnel Support Center
Attn: DPSC-PLT
2800 South 20th Street
Philadelphia, PA 19101

Source: https://assist.dla.mil -- Downloaded: 2026-10-26T09:22Z
Check the source to verify that this is the current version before use.